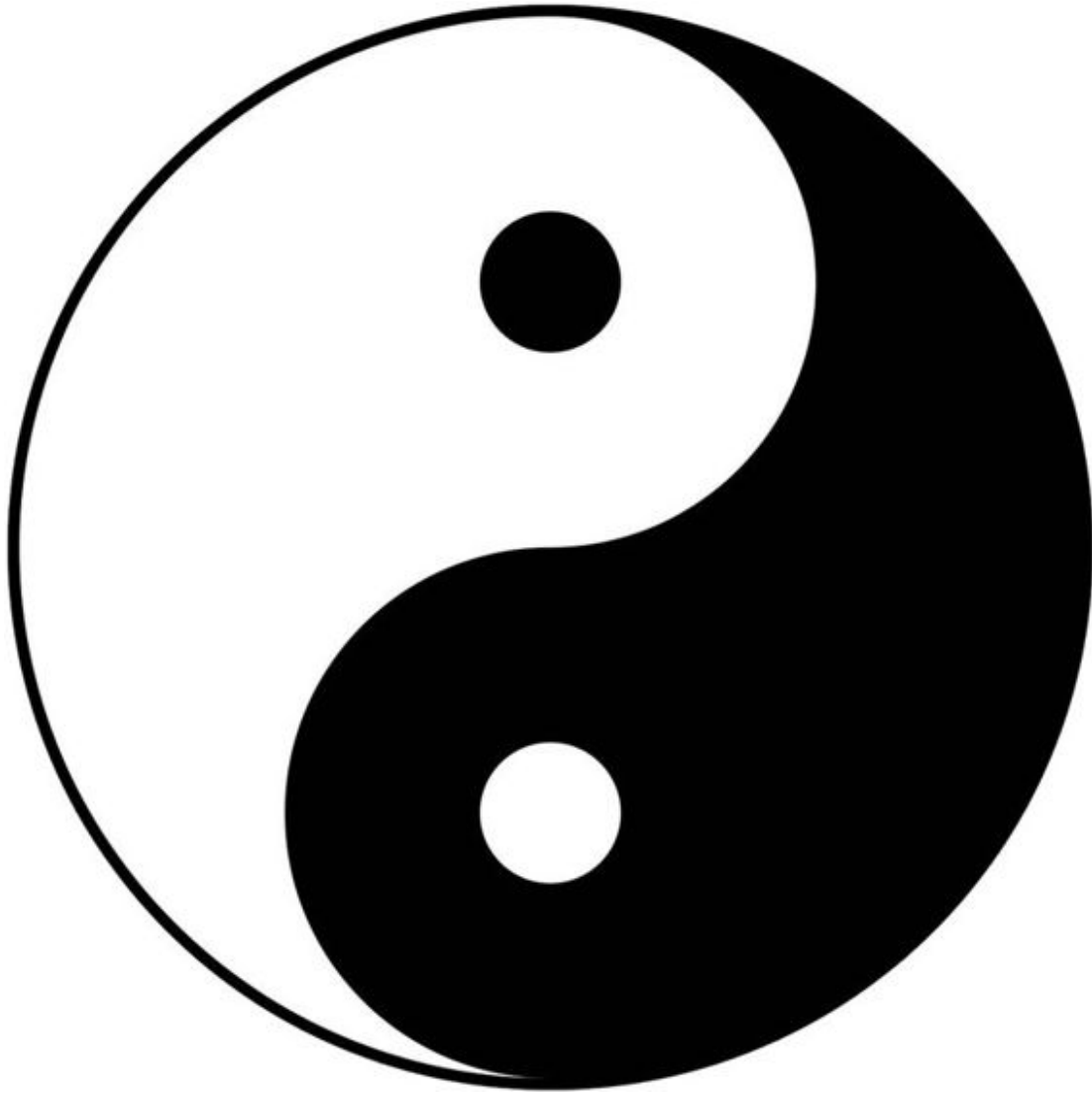


## Eastern philosophy



Until quite recently, Western philosophy developed in isolation from the traditions of China and India. The division between religion and philosophy was less clear-cut in the East, where adherence to a religion involved acceptance of its moral philosophy, and philosophy assumed belief in a religious, or at least unsupported, metaphysical explanation. The first great Eastern philosophers, such as Laozi and Confucius in China and Siddhartha Gautama in India, were roughly contemporary with the first Greek philosophers, but their emphasis on morals anticipated Athenian philosophy. In some respects, their conclusions were strikingly similar, but with the arrival of Christianity, Eastern and Western philosophies became

marked by differences rather than similarities. In the 19th century, some Western philosophers 'discovered' Indian religion and philosophy, and realized the similarity to the views of German idealism in particular. More recently, the religious aspects of Eastern philosophies have taken precedence, while philosophical thinking in the East has come under Western influences.